

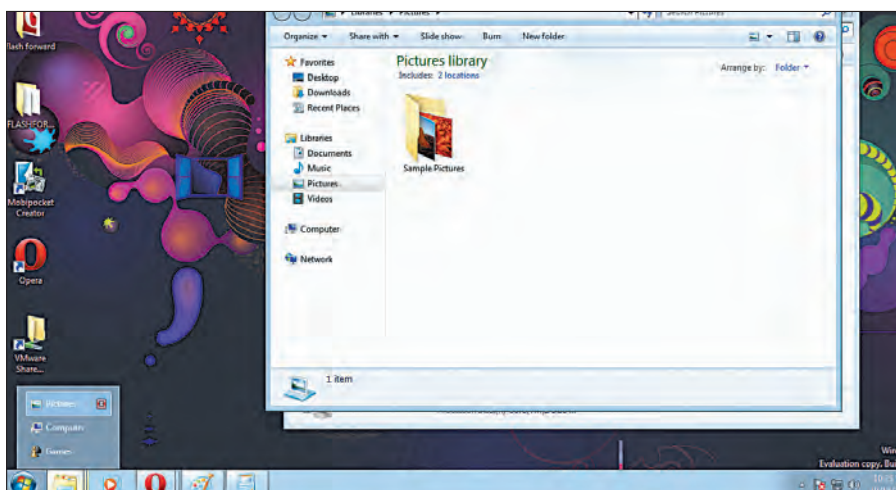
Sorry, Keyboard Warrior

UI design is dedicated exclusively for use with the mouse, though Windows does a respectable job of keeping the keyboarders happy

Less is More

Another UI “Law” is Hick’s law, which essentially says “more buttons means more time to choose one”. It’s the reason iTunes doesn’t have a Stop button

Feature



There's some good and bad here, but nothing that warrants the words “love” or “hate”

screen, spread out like a pile of papers, and brought back together. Then came Microsoft’s Aero in Vista, and the Compiz/XGL/Beryl/whatever in Linux systems. Working with windows became so much more satisfying — grabbing your Linux desktop and rotating it like a cube, watching windows scroll like a pack of cards — it all became so much more real. A little more like driving a car.

Yes, its Direct Manipulation at work here, for a change. Now that even the most basic graphics card can handle the load of windows that are rendered as 3D objects, we can look forward to even more DM-oriented interfaces. BumpTop, for example, tries to bring the direct manipulation joy that you get out of your physical desk to your virtual desktop (it’s even got pie menus, incidentally). It lets you grab files and toss them around, resize their icons, and all sorts of things that you can do with real physical files.

And while we’re on the subject of DM, we can use it to explain one thing that’s baffled us for ages.

The case of the Enter that renames

If you’re using the keyboard to navigate the Finder on the Mac, you’re in for a nasty surprise if you try to open a file or folder by hitting the [Enter] key; for the Mac interprets hitting [Enter] as your desire to rename the

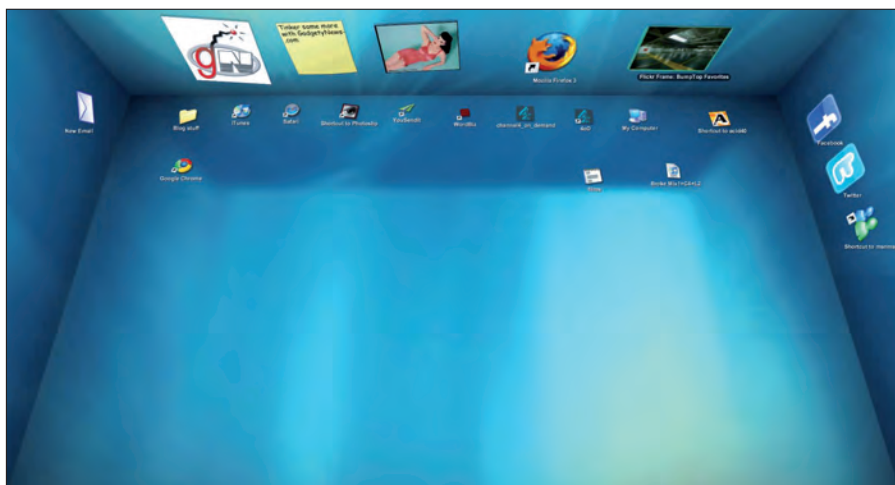
file, rather than open it. After spending days reading about the science of UI design, we were able to explain nearly everything we saw and interacted with, except for this one silly, silly thing. And so, we turned to Bruce Tognazzini, who founded the Apple Human Interface Group. As you read, remember that DM is a mouse-centric philosophy: “Apple wants to facilitate direct manipulation, and that means that you can change the names of things without having to go somewhere else, like a properties window, to do so. There is no need or reason for someone to click on a document with the mouse, then move to the keyboard to press the Return key to open it when double-clicking will do.”

It’s a fair argument, but it confirms another thing that’s annoyed us about Mac OS X: Apple doesn’t expect you be using the keyboard that much; tough luck, keyboard warriors.

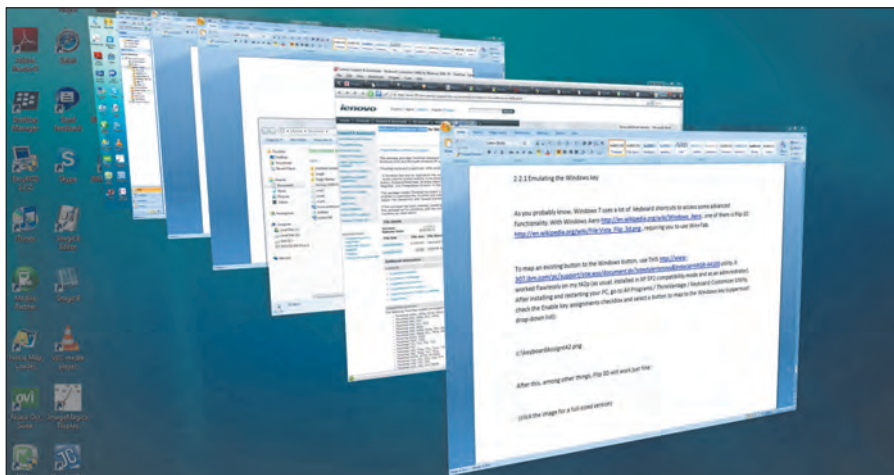
There. Now we can get some sleep.

Endnote

If, by any chance, none of these mysteries have ever bothered you, you might want to



It may not be the most productive of interfaces, but BumpTop’s full of DM fun



Many may hate it, but Aero did make Windows a lot more fun

re-think what you’re doing with your life. Too many TV rays mush-ifying your brain, perhaps?

Without knowing what makes for an optimal experience, you can’t begin to customise your OS to work better for you. For example, Ubuntu users: get rid of that silly top panel and reclaim the top-right corner for something better — like closing maximised windows. And don’t think you’re being a “power-user” by using small icons in toolbars — you’re actually slowing yourself down.

If, armed with this new knowledge, you’re able to solve your own unique UI mystery, share it with people. If you manage to customise a program in a way that makes the UI better, share that too. You could all be part of Digt’s Famous Five Hundred (UI Chapter). 